ANKYRA

Reading the Bible on Your Own

Where to start, how long for, and what to do when you stall.

Most people do not stop reading the Bible because it is too hard. They stop because they started in the wrong place, aimed too high, missed four days, and felt too guilty to pick it up again. All of those are fixable.

1. Start with a Gospel, not with Genesis

Starting at page one on the first of January is how most people give up by February: Leviticus is a wall. Start with a Gospel instead. Mark is the shortest account of Jesus, it moves quickly, and it assumes you know nothing. The plan overleaf takes you through the whole of it in six weeks.

2. Ten minutes, most days

Not chapters, not a target. A short passage, read properly, on most days will change you more in a year than three-hour sessions twice a month. Pick a time when you are already somewhere predictable (before work, on the bus, last thing) and put it there.

3. Ask three questions

1. **What does this show me about God?**
   About the Father, about Jesus, about the Spirit. Start here, always. If you start with yourself you end up reading a self-help book.

2. **What does this show me about people?**
   What we are like, what we need, what we get wrong. Often uncomfortable, which is usually the sign you have understood it.

3. **What do I do about it today?**
   One thing. Something you could actually do before you go to bed.

4. Say something back

When you have finished, talk to God about what you just read. Not a formula. “Thank you that you are like that” is a prayer. So is “I do not understand this”, and so is “help me with the thing I have just written down.” Thirty seconds is fine.

> **If you miss a week (and you will)**
>
> Do not try to catch up. Do not start again from the beginning. Just tick the next box tonight and carry on. More people lose this habit to guilt than ever lose it to difficulty, and God is not marking your attendance.

Mark in six weeks

FOUR READINGS A WEEK, THREE DAYS OFF

Four short readings a week, whichever days suit you. Tick each one as you go: on paper, or by tapping the boxes if you are reading this on a phone or laptop. They are the same passages as the list on the Discussion Sheet, so if you meet with others you can keep a week ahead.

Week 1

- [ ] **Mark 1:1–20** John the Baptist; Jesus baptised; four called
- [ ] **Mark 1:21–45** A day in Capernaum, and a man with leprosy
- [ ] **Mark 2:1–17** Forgiving sins; calling a tax collector
- [ ] **Mark 2:18–3:6** Sabbath arguments; the first plot

Week 2

- [ ] **Mark 3:7–35** The Twelve chosen; opposition grows
- [ ] **Mark 4:1–34** Parables: sower, lamp, mustard seed
- [ ] **Mark 4:35–5:20** The storm calmed; the man among the tombs
- [ ] **Mark 5:21–43** Two desperate people, one long wait

Week 3

- [ ] **Mark 6:1–29** Rejected at home; the Twelve sent; John killed
- [ ] **Mark 6:30–56** Five thousand fed; a walk on the water
- [ ] **Mark 7:1–30** What actually makes a person unclean
- [ ] **Mark 7:31–8:21** More bread, and still not seeing it

Week 4

- [ ] **Mark 8:22–38** “Who do you say I am?” and the cost
- [ ] **Mark 9:1–29** Transfigured; a father’s honest prayer
- [ ] **Mark 9:30–50** Who is the greatest?
- [ ] **Mark 10:1–31** Marriage, children, and money

Week 5

- [ ] **Mark 10:32–52** Serving rather than ruling; blind Bartimaeus
- [ ] **Mark 11:1–33** Into Jerusalem; the temple cleared
- [ ] **Mark 12:1–44** Traps, questions, and a widow’s two coins
- [ ] **Mark 13:1–37** What is coming, and staying awake

Week 6

- [ ] **Mark 14:1–52** The last supper; Gethsemane; the arrest
- [ ] **Mark 14:53–72** On trial, while Peter denies him
- [ ] **Mark 15:1–47** Crucified
- [ ] **Mark 16:1–8** The empty tomb

Three practical things

Which Bible. If you are buying one, a CSB or an NIV is a good choice; *Choosing an English Bible Translation* compares the rest. The Bible on Ankyra is the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), free to read with notes.

Use the audio. The free YouVersion Bible app will read any passage aloud. Mark takes about ninety minutes end to end. If reading is hard work for you, listening is not cheating.

Paper beats a phone if you can manage it: nothing on a paper Bible buzzes at you halfway through.

When you finish Mark

ROUGHLY IN THIS ORDER

No rule says it has to be this order, but it builds on itself. Finish one before starting another.

BOOK	LENGTH	WHY
Matthew	28 chapters	The fullest account of Jesus' teaching, and the book with the fullest notes on Ankyra.
Acts	28 chapters	What happened next, and how the church began. Reads like a story; same author as Luke.
Ephesians	6 chapters	What being a Christian actually means. Short but dense: a few verses at a time.
John	21 chapters	The fourth Gospel. Slower and deeper on who Jesus is.
Genesis 1–12	12 chapters	Where the whole story starts: creation, the fall, and God's promise to Abraham.
Proverbs	31 chapters	Blunt, practical wisdom. One chapter a day fills a month.
Psalms	150 songs	For when you have no words of your own. Try 23, 51, 103, 139.
1 John	5 chapters	Short, and mostly about how you can know you are actually in.
Romans	16 chapters	The fullest explanation of the gospel anywhere. Worth waiting for.

Four honest problems

ALL OF THEM NORMAL

"I don't feel anything when I read it." Most days you will not, and that measures nothing. Feeling follows knowing rather than leading it. Keep turning up; it sorts itself out over months, not mornings.

"I don't understand what I just read." Expected. Parts of it were difficult for the people who first heard them. Mark the verse, carry on, and look at the notes on Ankyra or ask someone at your church. A question carried for a few days often gets a better answer than one looked up in ten seconds.

"There is a bit that troubles me." Do not skip it and do not pretend. Write it down and say it out loud to someone. Faith that has never met a hard passage is not strong, just untested.

"I keep forgetting." That is a place problem, not a memory one. Attach it to something you already do without thinking (the kettle, the commute, sitting down at your desk) and leave the Bible physically there.

Nobody is checking. There is no register and no one is ahead of you. The only thing needed to start again is to open it tonight.

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